



CHRISTINA HOUSE Los Angeles Times

DANCING IN THE DUST AT COACHELLA

Sophia Peterson, left, and Ariana Pellegrini of Los Angeles get in the groove Friday at the desert music festival in Indio, where hazardous dust storms and even rain are possible this weekend. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

STATE IS BILKED IN FRAUD SCHEME

Prosecutors say the hospice scam cost California’s medical system \$267 million.

By RICHARD WINTON AND HANNAH FRY

Twenty-one people are facing charges as part of a massive hospice fraud scheme that prosecutors say bilked California’s medical system out of \$267 million.

State Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta this week announced the results of an investigation called Operation Skip Trace. Five accused principal conspirators were arrested on suspicion of a host of felonies, including insurance fraud, money laundering, conspiracy and identity theft for their alleged role in a sophisticated hospice scam operating across Southern California.

If convicted, each could face at least a decade behind bars.

State prosecutors allege the defendants purchased on the dark web the personal identifying information of non-California residents and, without their knowledge, enrolled them in Medi-Cal through Covered California. The defendants then bought hospice companies and began billing the state for services they never rendered, according to the criminal complaint.

“Over the life of this fraud scheme, not a single legitimate hospice service was ever provided, yet millions were billed in a brazen, calculated scheme that exploited the Medi-Cal system,” Bonta said Thursday. “This wasn’t a mistake or a loophole; it was deliberate fraud. This kind of abuse

[See Fraud, A9]

Swalwell is accused of sexual assaults

Misconduct is also alleged with 3 other women. Gubernatorial candidate denies wrongdoing.

By Seema Mehta, Dakota Smith and Nicole Nixon

Rep. Eric Swalwell, a Democratic front-runner in the hotly contested California governor’s race, was accused of sexual assault and misconduct by a former staff member and other women, according to reports published on Friday.

The woman who worked for the Northern California congressman said that she had a consensual relationship at times but that he sexually assaulted her twice when she was too inebriated to consent, according to a report by the San Francisco Chronicle. Three other women also have accused Swalwell of sexual misconduct, including receiving unsolicited nude photos from the Democrat, according to CNN.

The allegations against Swalwell have his campaign teetering on collapse, with powerful labor organizations and other major supporters pulling their endorsements and dropping political ads promoting the once-promising candidate. U.S. Sen. Adam Schiff, one of many prominent Democrats who supported Swal-

well, and others have called on him to drop out of the race.

Swalwell had been gaining traction in the crowded field, and the controversy completely upends the race just as voters are starting to pay attention.

“It’s like a bomb went off,” said Mike Madrid, a Republican strategist who runs the research nonprofit Latino Working Class Project.

Swalwell’s staff member was 21 years old when she started working for the congressman, who is nearly two decades her senior, and said she did not report the incidents to police because of fears she would not be believed.

“I have no skin in the game of who becomes governor of California, but I feel people have a right to know whether the person who leads a state that is a safe haven for so many women actually treats women with dignity,” the woman, who was not identified because she is the alleged victim of sexual assault, told the

[See Swalwell, A8]

Bad Bunny effect has helped raise Telemundo’s cool factor

Network is one of the nation’s hottest news outlets

By MEG JAMES

A few years ago, some were predicting the demise of Spanish-language television.

Most of the Latino population growth over two decades has come from U.S. births, outpacing the arrival of immigrants. The thinking was that because most U.S.-born Latinos speak English and can consume a wide array of media, Spanish-language TV would recede in relevance.

But Telemundo has de-

fied such forecasts to become one of the nation’s hottest news outlets.

The NBCUniversal-owned, Spanish-language network, a longtime underdog, has been notching viewership gains in advance of its highly anticipated coverage of this summer’s FIFA World Cup championships.

Last year, Telemundo increased its audience for its evening news, anchored by Julio Vaqueiro, by 11% over the previous year, according to Nielsen data. Its Los Angeles station, KVEA Channel 52, has surpassed en-

trenched giants Walt Disney Co.’s KABC and Univision’s KMEX, attracting more viewers for its local evening and late-night newscasts.

The Miami-based division has a strong social media presence. Its Telemundo Noticias (News) account boasts 16 million followers on TikTok, topping ABC News, CNN and Fox News.

Cultural and demographic shifts have helped fuel Telemundo’s rise. After more than a decade of immigration declines, border crossings surged during

[See Telemundo, A12]

L.A. sounds alarm over Olympic costs

‘Bankruptcy cannot be the legacy’: City and LA28 officials wrangle over terms.

By JAMES RAINEY

Los Angeles officials are expressing growing fears that taxpayers and the city treasury could be hit with a round of crippling costs to support the 2028 Summer Olympics if the city doesn’t ink a rigorous deal to assure a “zero-cost” Games.

Some city officials have long been concerned that taxpayers could be left with massive bills if the Olympics don’t generate the income organizers have promised. Delays in finalizing a deal between City Hall and the Olympics committee have heightened those tensions.

The exact costs to L.A. and other local governments remain unknown, as officials wait to hear from LA28 and federal security agencies about exactly what services they will need. Recent controversy over the ties between Casey Wasserman, the head of the L.A. Olympics, and Jeffrey Epstein have added to the uncertainty over the finances in the minds of some city leaders.

City Atty. Hydee Feldstein Soto and Councilmember Monica Rodriguez both issued letters demanding a contract pledging that LA28 cover any of the city’s future costs that arise as the city plays host to hundreds of thousands of athletes and fans.

The contract, more than six months overdue, is needed “to foreclose any scenario in which funds might go back to the wealthy backers and investors of the LA 28 organization without reimbursing taxpayer funded extraordinary costs,” the city attorney wrote to council members.

Rodriguez agreed in a separate letter this week that the city needs a contract that ensures that the Olympics organization will pay any excess costs for policing, transportation, trash pickup and more, so that taxpayers are not burdened or “core city services” slashed.

That should take priority over the private nonprofit LA28 building a “Legacy

[See Olympics, A9]



AFP/Getty Images

COMMUTERS pass a man holding the Iranian flag in Tehran on the third day of the fragile ceasefire.

Vance warns Iran not to ‘play us’

Vice president will open first direct talks with Tehran. Lebanon is a central dispute.

By GAVIN J. QUINTON

WASHINGTON — Vice President JD Vance departed Friday for Islamabad, Pakistan, to open the first direct negotiations aimed at ending the war between the United States and Iran.

Together with a delegation of deeply mistrusting negotiators from Tehran, Vance is tasked with striking a lasting peace between rival nations that have failed to keep promises made days ago in a delicate last-minute ceasefire. Ongoing military activity in the Middle East and disagreements over Iran’s control of key shipping routes have left the diplo-

matic effort vulnerable to collapse before the talks even begin.

“If the Iranians are willing to negotiate in good faith, we’re certainly willing to extend the open hand,” Vance told reporters before boarding Air Force Two. “If they’re gonna try and play us, then they’re gonna find that the negotiating team is not that receptive.”

On Tuesday, President Trump called off his plans to unleash “hell” on Iran based on assurances that it would lift its blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, but traffic through the vital waterway was still at a trickle Friday, as more than 600 ships remained stranded in the Persian Gulf, according to marine tracking data. Trump accused Iran on Thursday of doing a “very poor job, dishonorable some would say,” of allowing oil through the strait.

[See Iran, A4]



NASA/Associated Press

ARTEMIS II RETURNS

The capsule carrying the astronauts back from their historic lunar mission splashes down off the coast of San Diego on Friday. **NATION, A5**

U.S. investigates NFL media deals

Some ask if league’s antitrust exemption applies to streamers. **BUSINESS, A10**

GOP candidates clash in top race

Knives are out as two Republicans vie for Gov. Gavin Newsom’s seat. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

A stray shower. L.A. Basin: 72/55. **B8**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A13**



Zaslav’s golden parachute would hit new heights as Warner faces layoffs

By MEG JAMES

Even among the lofty realm of golden parachutes, Warner Bros. Discovery Chief Executive David Zaslav’s proposed payday stands out.

Zaslav, one of the most richly compensated executives in America, is poised to receive as much as \$887 million to depart the company once it is absorbed by David Ellison’s Paramount Skydance, Warner Bros. Discovery disclosed in a recent

proxy statement.

That amount “represents one of the highest golden parachute estimates ever observed,” investor advisory firm Institutional Shareholder Services wrote in a report this week. “Support for the golden parachute proposal is not warranted.”

Warner shareholders on April 23 will vote on the company’s \$111-billion sale to Ellison’s Paramount — a meaningful mark as Ellison and his team race to line up the approvals for the indus-

try-resaping deal, which they hope to finalize this summer. That vote is binding.

The acquisition is expected to trigger substantial layoffs and other cost cuts as the new owners consolidate two legendary studios and TV operations, including dozens of cable channels.

Stockholders also will be asked to weigh in on Zaslav’s compensation package, although that vote is nonbinding.

Several factors contrib-

[See CEO, A12]